Stress Management for Students

Introduction to Stress

Stress is the body's and mind's response to any demand or pressure, whether real or perceived. The term was introduced into biology by the Hungarian-Canadian scientist Hans Selye in 1936. Some stress is helpful: eustress, or positive stress, such as the excitement before a match or an interview, motivates us to perform better. Distress, or negative stress, happens when pressure is too high or lasts too long and we feel unable to cope. For students, common stressors include examinations, heavy syllabus, competition and comparison with others, career worries, parental expectations, financial concerns, relationship problems and the pressure of social media. A moderate amount of stress is normal, but chronic stress harms health and performance.

How the Body Reacts to Stress

When a person perceives a threat, the brain triggers the fight-or-flight response. The adrenal glands release the hormones adrenaline and cortisol, the heart beats faster, breathing quickens, muscles tense and blood sugar rises, preparing the body to face or flee the danger. This response is useful for short emergencies, but if it stays switched on for weeks because of constant pressure, high cortisol levels can weaken the immune system, disturb sleep, raise blood pressure and affect mood and memory.

What Are the Common Signs of Stress?

Stress shows itself in four ways. Physical signs include headaches, muscle tension and body aches, tiredness, stomach upset or changes in appetite, a racing heartbeat, sweating, frequent colds and trouble sleeping. Emotional signs include anxiety, irritability, mood swings, feeling overwhelmed, sadness and loss of interest in activities. Cognitive or mental signs include difficulty concentrating, forgetfulness, constant worrying, negative thinking and blanking out in exams. Behavioural signs include procrastination, avoiding responsibilities, withdrawing from friends, nail-biting, changes in eating habits, increased use of caffeine, screens or substances, and restlessness. Recognising these signs early is the first step to managing stress.

Name Three Healthy Ways to Manage Exam Stress

Three healthy ways to manage exam stress are planning and organising the study time, relaxing with breathing exercises or meditation, and taking care of sleep, food and exercise. First, make a realistic timetable, break the syllabus into small, manageable portions, set daily goals, start early and revise regularly instead of last-minute cramming, and use techniques such as the Pomodoro method of 25 minutes of focused study followed by a 5-minute break. Second, practise relaxation: slow deep breathing (for example, breathe in for four counts, hold for four, breathe out for six), progressive muscle relaxation, mindfulness meditation or yoga for 10 minutes a day calms the nervous system. Third, look after the body: sleep seven to eight hours, as memory is strengthened during sleep; eat regular balanced meals with fruits, nuts and plenty of water; limit caffeine, energy drinks and junk food; and exercise daily. Other helpful strategies include talking to friends, family, teachers or a counsellor, avoiding comparison with others, practising positive self-talk, taking short breaks for hobbies such as music, sport or art, limiting social media, doing previous question papers to build confidence, and focusing on effort rather than perfect results. On the exam day, reach early, read the paper carefully, and manage time.

How Does Exercise Reduce Stress?

Exercise reduces stress in several ways. Physical activity releases endorphins, natural chemicals in the brain that improve mood and act as natural painkillers, often called the "feel-good" hormones. It lowers the levels of stress hormones such as cortisol and adrenaline over time. It uses up the energy produced by the fight-or-flight response, relaxes tense muscles and improves sleep, which in turn reduces stress. Exercise also boosts self-confidence, provides a break from worries, and increases blood flow and oxygen to the brain, improving concentration and memory. Activities such as brisk walking, jogging, cycling, swimming, dancing, badminton, yoga and team sports for even 20 to 30 minutes a day can make a difference. Regular exercise also lowers the risk of anxiety and depression.

When to Seek Help

If stress or low mood lasts for more than two weeks, interferes with studies, sleep or relationships, or if a student feels hopeless or has thoughts of harming themselves, it is important to talk to a trusted person and seek professional help. Asking for help is a sign of strength. College counsellors and doctors can help. In India, Tele-MANAS, the National Tele Mental Health Programme launched in October 2022, offers free, 24-hour support on the toll-free number 14416 or 1-800-891-4416 in many languages, and the Kiran helpline 1800-599-0019 provides mental health support. The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017 recognises the right to mental healthcare. Tamil Nadu's 104 health helpline also offers counselling. Parents and teachers can help by creating a supportive atmosphere and avoiding unhealthy comparison.

Stress and Students in India

Competitive entrance exams such as NEET, JEE and board examinations create heavy pressure. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's annual event "Pariksha Pe Charcha", started in 2018, is an interaction with students, parents and teachers about handling exam stress. Many Indian schools now have counsellors and wellness programmes, and universities in Chennai run student counselling cells. The traditional practices of yoga, pranayama and meditation are widely used in India for stress relief.

Long-Term Stress Management Habits

Build a routine, keep a balance between study and leisure, spend time with friends, practise gratitude by noting three good things each day, keep a journal, avoid procrastination, learn to say no, and maintain hobbies. Time management and setting realistic goals prevent stress from building up. It helps to treat mistakes as learning opportunities.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include stigma around mental health and academic pressure. Schools and colleges are increasingly adding mental health education, peer support and digital tools such as meditation apps.

Quick Facts

- Common signs of stress include headaches, poor sleep, irritability, anxiety and difficulty concentrating.
- Healthy ways to manage exam stress: planning study time, deep breathing or meditation, and good sleep, food and exercise.
- Exercise reduces stress by releasing endorphins and lowering cortisol.
- Tele-MANAS (14416) is India's free 24-hour mental health helpline launched in October 2022.
- Hans Selye introduced the term stress in 1936.